eventually reaching the close with six wickets down. Even so, we were pleased to have prevailed against tough opposition in tough conditions, completing a notable trifecta in winning the T20 series, ODI series and Test series.

In cricket – as in rugby – there has always been, and there remains, a strong bond between South Africans and New Zealanders. In temperament, in general outlook, in an inherent determination to guts it out and be courageous, the two sporting communities seem to have much in common. The contest is always fierce, and there are often flashpoints of temper, but there remains an underlying mutual respect on both sides.

The Black Caps are my favourite and most respected opponents in international cricket; you could say they are my No. 2 team. Characterised by such celebrated players as Brendon McCullum and Daniel Vettori, they are never less than highly competitive on the field and they are invariably great people off the field.

Next stop ... England, via the Swiss Alps.

Sports administrators often receive criticism, some of it deserved, but credit should be given when credit is due, and credit was due to Cricket South Africa for accepting Gary Kirsten's unusual proposal and finding the budget for us to prepare for the England tour by holding a training camp with explorer Mike Horn in Switzerland.

Mike is a special person, who has accomplished many remarkable achievements, such as taking six months to swim the 6 992 kilometres from the source to the mouth of the Amazon River and walking to the North Pole in the middle of winter in 61 days of total darkness. His extraordinary energy and enthusiasm as a leader and guide combined with the breathtaking scenery of summer in the Alps to create a magical experience.

Each evening he regaled us with tales of his experiences, underlining the value of daring to have big dreams and of taking enough time to